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THE NETHERLANDS

Dutch households weather higher energy prices as income growth cushions impact

ING household data for the Dutch economy shows that average spending on fuel and energy is now higher than in 2022. But as incomes have risen substantially, the share of income spent on fuel and energy is still significantly lower than it was four years ago



The rise in energy prices has not led to a broad-based deterioration in affordability, including among the lowest-income households.

The Middle East crisis has not triggered a repeat of 2022

Since the outbreak of the Middle East conflict at the end of February, energy prices have remained elevated. This has been particularly evident in the oil market, where prices have far exceeded 2025 levels due to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz. Natural gas prices, which are also important for electricity costs, have increased as well, but have remained closer to levels seen in previous years.

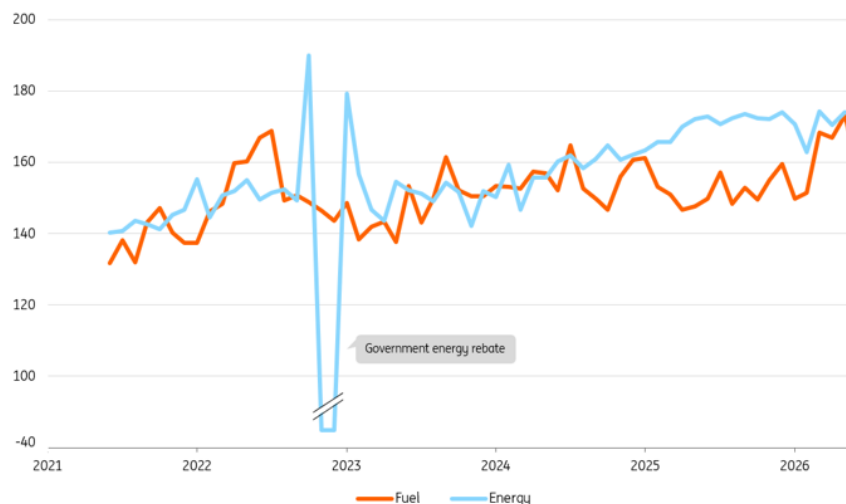
Initial concerns about a new affordability crisis were significant, but have eased as oil prices retreated from their peak levels. To assess the impact on households, we looked at new ING data on spending patterns. While the share of household income spent on fuel and energy has

increased, it remains below the levels seen during the 2022 energy crisis through June.

As chart 1 shows, the average amount spent on fuel and energy remains historically high. However, for the households in our sample, most of the increase in energy bills occurred in 2023 and 2024. The current crisis has not yet had a significant impact. This is not surprising given the delayed pass-through to household energy contracts and the relatively muted rise in gas prices. Fuel spending is still near the highs seen in 2022. This is consistent with fuel prices responding very quickly to changes in oil prices and oil prices responding more significantly to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

The nominal amount spent on fuel and energy is at or close to a peak

Average monthly spending per household in euro, seasonally-adjusted



Source: ING transaction data, calculations ING Research

Household energy costs have been stable, while fuel has reacted more quickly

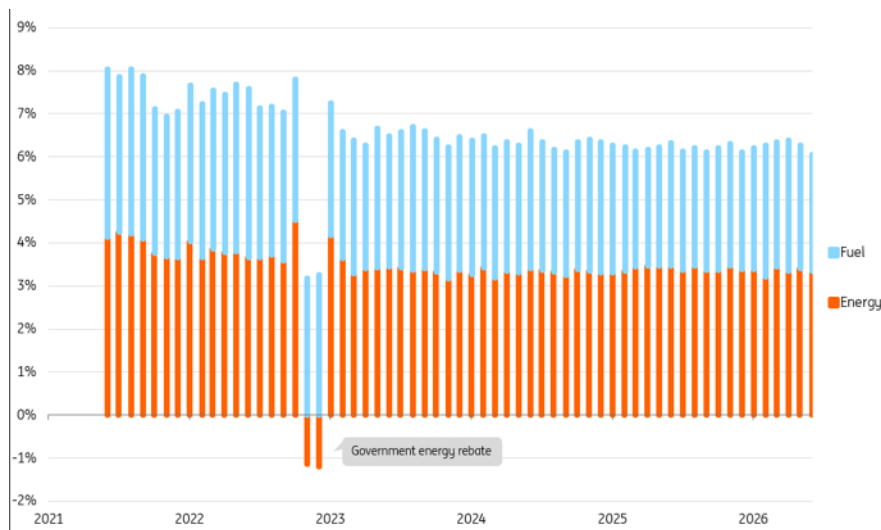
As a share of income, energy bills have remained fairly steady so far this year, accounting for around 3.4% in our sample. Fuel spending has shown a more noticeable increase, rising from 2.7% of income in December to 3.1% in April. Since then, however, that share has started to come down as oil prices have fallen from their peak and household incomes have increased.

Overall, the impact of the Middle East war on the most directly affected spending categories has therefore been muted. In June, the average amount of income spent on fuel and energy was 6.1%. That is back to where it was in December of last year and down from 6.4% in April. Income spent on energy and fuel therefore remains far from the 2022 levels of well above 7%.

Of course, there are no guarantees for the months ahead. Household energy bills adjust with a lag and could therefore still rise as a share of income. But given current natural gas prices, we are far from expecting a return to the levels seen in 2022. While oil and gas prices have moved up substantially since the Middle East war reignited, both remain significantly below the peaks seen this spring. That should temper any further increase in household energy costs in the coming months, although the global environment remains highly uncertain.

As share of household income, monthly spending on fuel and energy has not increased materially

Average monthly spending per household on energy and fuel*, as % of income, seasonally-adjusted



Source: ING transaction data, calculations ING Research.

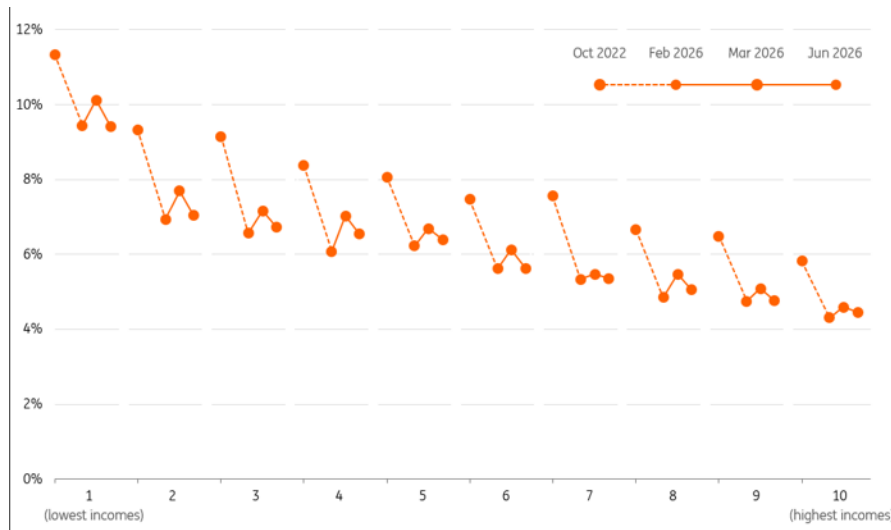
* Net payments to energy suppliers and spending at fuel stations

No broad-based deterioration across income groups

We find little evidence of a material deterioration in affordability across income groups. For the lowest 10% of incomes in our sample, fuel and energy spending remains higher in absolute terms, but the share of income devoted to these costs has changed little. Some income groups have seen more pronounced changes, mostly related to fuel spending. But overall, the data does not point to a broad-based deterioration in affordability. All income groups now spend less as part of their income on energy and fuel than in 2022 before the energy subsidies kicked in.

Little difference in spending on fuel and energy between income groups

Monthly spending on energy and fuel* as % of household income, average per income decile, seasonally-adjusted



Source: ING transaction data, calculations ING Research.

* Sum of net payments to energy suppliers and spending at fuel stations

Confidence has weakened more than actual spending

What this means for the Dutch economy is that while consumer confidence has been bouncing around significantly in response to the conflict in the Middle East and concerns about higher inflation, spending in the categories most exposed to energy prices has not changed materially as a share of household income. This is also true for the lowest-income decile in our sample. This finding is consistent with general spending patterns, which have remained resilient despite the large shock to consumer confidence.

So while the flare-up of the conflict in the Middle East has caused energy prices to spike again, aggregated transaction data shows that, on average, household finances remain quite resilient. We expect Dutch consumer spending growth to remain muted but still positive, as underlying income growth supports improved spending despite higher inflation and weak confidence.

About the data

This analysis is based on aggregated transaction data from a panel of approximately 15,000 ING customers' households aged between 20 and 80. As the transaction data is

aggregated, neither the data nor the findings can be traced back to individual customers. The sample was drawn using stratified sampling by province and age group and subsequently weighted by age and income decile to better reflect the composition of Dutch households. The analysis includes only households with income from employment, social benefits/allowances or pensions. Self-employed households are excluded. As a result, the dataset is not a complete representation of the Dutch household population, and outcomes may differ from official Statistics Netherlands (CBS) figures.

Author

Bert Colijn

Chief Economist, Netherlands

bert.colijn@ing.com

Dimitry Fleming

Senior Data Analyst, Netherlands

Dimitry.Fleming@ing.com

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